

PEAS *Pisum sativum*

Harvested and eaten fresh, peas are a real sweet treat. Most peas will need to be shelled, but some, such as snow peas and sugar peas (also known as mangetouts) are edible-podded and can be eaten whole. Both are delicious eaten raw or cooked, and many varieties are grown for their edible pea shoots, which can be added to salads. Easy to grow, peas will also brighten up the garden with an attractive display of flowers.

	SPRING	SUMMER	FALL	WINTER
SOW/PLANT				
HARVEST				

SOWING

Dig in well-rotted manure or compost in the fall before sowing. Pea roots are nitrogen-fixing; they convert nitrogen from the air and store it in nodules on their roots. For this reason, they don't need any extra nitrogenous fertilizer. Peas prefer a sunny, moist site that will not get too hot or become waterlogged. A slightly alkaline pH is ideal.

Sow seed any time from late winter onward—seedlings can be started indoors and then transplanted when the soil warms up, or sown directly in the ground, although seedlings will need protection from frost with a cloche or cold frame. In some regions, seed can be



Plant out strong seedlings in springtime.

sown successively through spring until midsummer. Sow at a depth of 1.5–2 in (4–5 cm); leave at least a 2 in (5 cm) space between plants. Sow in single or double rows.

CROP CARE

Most peas will require at least a little support, so construct a framework for them using canes or netting—this will keep them upright and make the best use